B2 Writing

Writing a formal complaint email

Complain clearly and politely, explain the problem with facts, and ask for a specific solution.

A good complaint is firm but polite. It states the facts, explains the effect on you, and asks for a clear action. Angry or vague complaints are easier to ignore.

Paragraph	Purpose	Useful language
Opening	Say why you are writing	*I am writing to complain about the laptop I ordered on 3 May (order no. 48213).*
The problem	Facts: what, when, what went wrong	*The screen stopped working after two days, and the charger was missing.*
The effect	Why it matters to you	*As a result, I was unable to complete an important project.*
The request	The exact solution you want, and when	*I would therefore like a full refund within 14 days.*
Closing	Formal ending	*I look forward to your reply. Yours sincerely, ...*

Be specific. Dates, order numbers and amounts make a complaint credible. *I would like a replacement* is stronger than *Please do something*.

Common mistakes. Informal phrases such as *I'm really angry!!* or *Thanks, bye*. Use *I was very disappointed* and *Yours sincerely* (when you know the name) or *Yours faithfully* (after *Dear Sir or Madam*).

Practice

Make each sentence suitable for a formal complaint.

1. Hi guys, I'm writing because your delivery was rubbish.
2. The food was cold and the waiter was super rude.

3. Give me my money back now.

4. Write a closing line for an email that started "Dear Sir or Madam".

5. Add the effect: The hotel lost my booking. ___

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Dear Sir or Madam, I am writing to complain about a late delivery.
2. The food was served cold and the waiter was impolite.
3. I would like a full refund, please. / I would be grateful if you could refund the full amount.
4. I look forward to hearing from you. Yours faithfully, …
5. As a result, I had to find another hotel late at night and pay a higher price.